

The Dome of the Rock

Completed in 691–2 CE by the Umayyad Caliph Abd Al-Malik, the Dome of the Rock is a shrine on Temple Mount in Jerusalem; the earliest surviving Muslim monumental building (albeit with a few alterations), it is one of the city's defining landmarks. The site is important for Jews, Christians and Muslims, and the Dome replaces earlier temples on the location. It was initially intended to stand as a substitute for the Kaaba, the shrine of the great mosque at Mecca.

The octagonal plan was probably based on the Byzantine Chapel of St Mary, built in 451–8 CE on the road between Jerusalem and Bethlehem. Mounted on an elevated drum, the great dome is 20 metres (66 ft) in diameter and 20.5 metres (67 ft) high. It rises above 12 columns and 4 piers, with an octagonal walkway of 16 columns and 8 piers. Light pours in through 16 windows evenly spaced around the drum, and 40 more in the lower, octagonal part. It has been claimed that around 100,000 gold coins were melted down for the dome's original exterior.

